but she couldn’t go down to get them either. But maybe she could go to the barracks. It wouldn’t take that long—a few hours. Reinhardt would still be sleeping, hopefully not even realizing she’d been gone. And no one would see her in the darkness. She could take a candle to light her way, though with the full moon, she wasn’t sure she needed one.

Rose stood and quietly made her way across the wooden floorboards. She changed her clothes, took the candle from the holder next to her bed, along with the matches, and slipped them into her pocket. She went out on the porch, where her boots waited. The air was fresh and clear—no trace of burning coal like in the center of town. Moonlight struck the ground like a torch. She found her way through the clearing to the path without needing to light the candle. Not wanting to carry it, she left it by the side of the path, reminding herself to pick it up on her return.

She navigated the switchbacks slowly, recalling tree roots that crossed the path in certain spots and which she could easily stumble over and fall if she wasn’t careful. Tiny steps carried her down. The church bell rang once, signaling the half hour. She hadn’t checked the time before leaving; she didn’t even know where the clock might be in the house. She guessed it must be three or four in the morning. But by the time she reached the street, the sun was already over the horizon, the town enveloped in a fuzzy gray light.

No one was on the street. The only sounds were the rustle of the river nearby. It was so peaceful that Rose found it hard to believe the war was still ongoing. Reinhardt was convinced it would end today or the next day. When she’d asked him how he saw that happening, he’d shrugged. “You’ll have a front-row seat,” he’d told her.

Arriving at the barracks, Rose took the steps two at a time. She wondered if all the Polish women had left. On the top floor, she found her four sketchbooks under the bunk bed. She put them in a cotton bag, along with the pencils and charcoal, which she slung across her body. Then she went back down the steps and outside.

The sky had changed. Blue shadows washed out the gray, and between the clouds, a strip of copper flowed like a river. She thought about Léa, André and Josef. Five days had passed. Surely they would have reached the Allied side by now. Rose touched the ring on her finger. The war was ending. Why couldn’t her promise end, too?